

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called 'Mother of the Planetary Spirits'

Āryā Graha Mātṛkā Nāma Dhāraṇī · Toh 660 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་མ་གཟའ་རྒྱལ་གྱི་མུ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའ་གི་བུ་སྟེན།

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "Mother of the Planetary Spirits," known in Sanskrit as the Āryā Graha Mātṛkā Nāma Dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as Pakma Zasam Kyi Yum Zhesbyawa'i Zung, is a dhāraṇī text centered on a powerful female deity who is venerated as the mother or sovereign of planetary spirits and celestial bodies. The text opens in the classic sūtra style, with the Buddha surrounded by an extensive assembly of gods, nāgas, yakṣas, and a full retinue of planetary and astral beings — including the Sun, Moon, and the named planets — reflecting the text's deep concern with cosmic and astrological forces and their relationship to Buddhist protective practice. As a dhāraṇī scripture, it belongs to the broader tradition of tantric or quasi-tantric ritual literature in which sacred formulae are presented as conferring protection and blessings through the power of enlightened beings. It is Toh 660 in the Kangyur, catalogued among the dhāraṇī collections of that canon.

In the language of India: Āryā Graha Mātṛkā Nāma Dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "Mother of the Planetary Spirits."

Homage to the noble Blessed Lady, Mother of the Planetary Spirits.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was in the great city of the pastoral lands, praised by a great multitude of gods (devas), nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, great mahoragas, māras, Yama the Lord of Death, the Sun, the Moon, Mars (the Red-eyed One), Jupiter (the Remaining Planet), Saturn, Venus (the Pure One), Mercury, Rāhu, the Comet (the Long-tailed One), and the twenty-eight lunar mansions, and many others. Seated upon a lion throne consecrated by the great vajra ornament of sacred commitment, together with many bodhisattvas, namely: the bodhisattva mahāsattva Vajrapāṇi, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Vajra the Fierce, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Vajra Host, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Vajra Bow, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Lord of the Vajra, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Vajra Ornament, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Vajra Light, the bodhisattva mahāsattva noble Avalokiteśvara, the bodhisattva mahāsattva the All-Seeing, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Glory of the World, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Lotus Crest, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Fully Bloomed Face, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Lotus Essence, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Lotus

Eyes, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mañjuśrī, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Maitreya, and many other such bodhisattvas — surrounded by and arrayed before hundreds of assemblies of bodhisattvas — he taught the Dharma. He taught the Dharma called "The Wish-fulfilling Jewel, the Ornament of the Great Array," good at the beginning, good in the middle, good at the end, excellent in meaning, excellent in word, unmixed, perfectly pure, and perfectly refined.

Then, through the blessing of the buddhas, Vajrapāṇi gazed upon that assembly, rose up, circumambulated the Blessed One many thousands of times through the blessing of his own miraculous power, and paid homage. He then seated himself with dignity and composure in the cross-legged posture before the Blessed One, gazed upon the assembly, joined his vajra-palms together at his own heart, and addressed the Blessed One with these words:

Blessed One, the planetary spirits are beings of fierce and ferocious form, beings of violent and savage form, beings of wrathful and angry mind, who inflict harm and injury upon sentient beings and rob them of their vitality. Some rob beings of their wealth and possessions. Some rob them of their very life. Some sentient beings who would live long lives they cause to die young. Thus do they inflict harm upon sentient beings. Therefore I ask the Blessed One to please teach a category of Dharma by which sentient beings may be protected.

The Blessed One declared: Vajrapāṇi, it is excellent, truly excellent, that out of compassion and for the benefit of sentient beings you ask the Tathāgata concerning this great secret, supremely secret teaching. I will explain it. Listen, retain it well, and take it to heart.

Concerning the planetary spirits of fierce and terrifying form, I shall teach the making of excellent offerings and good recitation — a secret that is more secret than secret.

They are honored by offerings, and when harm is done, they in turn cause harm. The colors of each of those planetary spirits, what pleases them, and the secret mantras and offerings that pacify the fierce and greatly majestic wrath of the gods, asuras, kinnaras (half-human spirit beings), nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas (flesh-eating demons), vetālas (reanimating spirits), humans, and others — all of these I shall set forth in due order.

Then from the very heart of the Blessed One Śākyamuni himself there blazed forth a ray of light called "Display of Compassion," which entered the crown of the heads of the planetary spirits. In that very instant the planetary spirits,

beginning with the Sun, rose up and addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened Buddha — you have appointed us as physicians for beings. We beseech the Blessed One to teach us a category of Dharma: namely, those who recite the Dharma that gathers us together and makes us useful — please teach what it is that will protect them, fully guard them, bring them peace and well-being, perform the rites of propitiation, avert punishments, turn away weapons, neutralize poison, kill poison, define boundaries, and bind the ground."

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Śākyamuni, taught the offerings and secret mantras for the planetary spirits.

According to the proper sequential arrangement of colors and directions, one makes a fragrant maṇḍala and draws petals of a lotus measuring twelve finger-widths, with a hub also twelve finger-widths across, beautifully adorned with four gates in due order. Upon the open lotus one is to visualize the god the Sun: his body is a mass of blazing glory like a great fire of ruby-red coals, his light equal to that of a thousand suns.

Om Meghokāya Svāhā.

To the east, the Moon, white in color. Om Śītāṃśa Ve Svāhā.

At the southeastern direction, Mars, with red eyes. Om Raktāṃga Kumārāya Svāhā.

In the direction of Yama (the south), Mercury — of the warrior class among the planetary spirits — saffron-yellow in color. Om Buddhāya Svāhā.

At the southwestern direction, Jupiter, reddish-yellow. Om Pṛhaspataye Svāhā.

In the western direction, Venus, white as a conch. Om Asurottamāya Svāhā.

In the direction of wind (the northwest), Saturn, extremely black like collyrium for the eyes. Om Kṛṣṇavarṇāya Svāhā.

In the direction of the inauspicious body (the northeast), Rāhu, dark red-black. Om Amṛtapriyāya Svāhā.

At the direction of the overlord (the east-northeast), Ketu, with a tail the color of a rain-cloud. Om Jyotiketave Svāhā.

At the eastern gate: the venerable Buddha. At the southern gate: Vajrapāṇi. At the western gate: the Protector of the World. At the northern gate: Mañjuśrī.

Outside the maṇḍala, in the north-east, are all the planetary spirits. In the south-east are the lunar mansions and the constellations. In the south-west are all harmful forces. In the north-west is the noble Great Reasoning One.

Outside the gates of the maṇḍala — to the east: Dhṛtarāṣṭra (Guardian of the East); to the south: Virūḍhaka; to the west: Virūpākṣa; to the north: Vaiśravaṇa.

Now the food offerings for each planetary spirit are as follows: for the Sun, a porridge of milk; for the Moon, a curd-rice dish; for Mars, a food of red beans mixed with flesh; for Jupiter, a load of excellent butter; for Mercury, fresh milk; for Venus, a load of curd; for Saturn, a food of black beans mixed with flesh blended with mung beans; for Rāhu, a sesame porridge; for Ketu, a sesame porridge with sesame seeds; and a relish of molasses.

The offering cake (torma) for the yakṣas is the curd-rice dish of Dhṛtarāṣṭra. For Virūḍhaka: curd with a food of beans mixed with flesh. For Virūpākṣa: a food of milk-porridge.

For Vaiśravaṇa: a food of curd of poor creature mixed with beans and flesh, blended with molasses and beer.

Flowers of the appropriate color for each in sequence are to be offered. Incense of the appropriate color for each in sequence is to be offered. Banners of the appropriate color for each in sequence are to be offered. A lamp is to be offered to each one individually. Offerings are to be made in accordance with the proper sequence.

A conch-shell bowl is to be filled with butter and honey, the five precious substances placed within it, a water offering presented, and the front face bound with a white silk scarf.

Vajrapāṇi, the following are the mantras that accomplish results when recited — the essence mantras of these planetary spirits. In the center of a maṇḍala of incense twelve finger-breadths across, made of incense matching the appropriate color for each in sequence, the offerings are to be made. Offering water is to be presented in a clay vessel, or copper or similar, or a vessel of gold or silver, and for each one individually the mantra is to be recited one hundred and eight times.

Vajrapāṇi, after that, the words of the dhāraṇī mantra called the Mother of the Planetary Spirits are then to be recited seven times. After that, all the planetary spirits — the Sun and the rest — will protect one. They will free one from the poverty of demonic possession. Those whose lifespan has been exhausted will come to live long.

Vajrapāṇi, furthermore, whatever monks, nuns, male lay practitioners, or female lay practitioners, or other sentient beings belonging to any birth among sentient beings, should hear this in the range of their ears — they too will not come to make a time of death at an untimely hour.

Vajrapāṇi, furthermore, whoever makes offerings in the center of the maṇḍala of the planetary spirits and recites and teaches the Dharma from this text day by day — all the planetary spirits will, in every respect, through their own selves, fulfill all that person's wishes completely. They will also bring an end to the poverty of that person's family line.

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, proclaimed the dhāraṇī called the Mother of the Planetary Spirits:

Namo buddhāya. Namō vajradhārāya. Namō padmadhārāya. Namō kumārāya. Namō grahāṇaṃ sarvāśa paripūrakāṇaṃ. Namō nakṣatrāṇaṃ. Namō dvādaśarāśināṃ. Tadyathā: oṃ buddhe buddhe, vajre vajre, padme padme, sara sara, prasara prasara, smara smara, krīḍaya krīḍaya, mārāya mārāya, mārdaya mārdaya, ghāṭaya ghāṭaya, sarva vighṇaṃ kuru kuru, mama kāryāṃ, chinda chinda, sarva duṣṭāṃ, kṣāpaya kṣāpaya, śānte śānte, dānte dānte, dāmaya dāmaya svāhā. Drutān darśaya, ātmanāṃ, rakṣa rakṣa māṃ, sarva sattvāṃś ca, sarva graha nakṣatra vidhvamsani vartaya, bhagavatī mahāmāye, prasādaya, sarva duṣṭāṃ, śodhaya sarva pāpaṃ, caṇḍe caṇḍe, turu turu, caṇḍeni caṇḍeni, muyu muyu, mucu mucu, vaha vaha, ugre ugratame, pūraya me, manorthaṃ paripūraya, sarva tathāgata adhiṣṭhite samaye svāhā. Oṃ svāhā. Hūṃ svāhā. Hrī svāhā. Dhruṃ svāhā. Dhriṃ svāhā. Padmadhārāya svāhā. Ādityāya svāhā. Saumāya svāhā. Dhāraṇīsutāya svāhā. Budhāya svāhā. Bṛhaspataye svāhā. Śukrāya svāhā. Kṛṣṇavarṇāya svāhā. Rāhave svāhā. Ketave svāhā. Vṛddhāya svāhā. Vajradhārāya svāhā. Padmadhārāya svāhā. Kumārāya svāhā. Sarva grahebhyaḥ svāhā. Sarva nakṣatrebhyaḥ svāhā. Sarva dvādaśarāśinibhyaḥ svāhā. Sarva upadravebhyaḥ svāhā. Oṃ sarva pidye hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā.

Vajrapāṇi, these words of the dhāraṇī mantra called the Mother of the Planetary Spirits — beginning from the seventh day of the waxing fortnight of

— having taken the restoration ceremony (poṣadha), one should make offerings and recite it every single day up to the fourteenth day of the fortnight; and then, from that time onward, should one read it continuously day and night in the month of Pisces, no danger of death will arise for that person for up to ninety-nine years. The danger of falling meteors and the danger of being afflicted by planetary spirits and wandering stars will not arise. One will come to remember one's past lives. All the planetary spirits will make offerings to that person. The planetary spirits will bestow upon that person the supreme of whatever one wishes. Thereupon those planetary spirits said "Excellent!" to the Blessed One, and then vanished from sight.

Translated from the long version belonging to the royal ministers and bodhisattvas. Subsequently, the layman Drakpa Gyaltsen carefully collated it against a Chinese exemplar at the secluded hermitage of the glorious Sakya and rendered it into a very pure form.

- The list of planetary spirits follows the traditional Tibetan astrological system. The renderings given match the standard identifications: རྩ་མེད་ཀྱི་ལྷ་ (the Red-eyed One) as Mars, རྩ་མེད་ཀྱི་ལྷ་ (the Remaining Planet) as Jupiter, རྩ་མེད་ཀྱི་ལྷ་ as Saturn, རྩ་མེད་ཀྱི་ལྷ་ as Venus, རྩ་མེད་ཀྱི་ལྷ་ as Mercury, རྩ་མེད་ཀྱི་ལྷ་ as Rāhu, and རྩ་མེད་ཀྱི་ལྷ་ (the Long-tailed One) as a comet or Ketu. These identifications are consistent across the Tibetan astrological tradition, though some scholars debate individual assignments.

- The directions assigned to the nine planetary spirits (navagraha) partly follow a variant scheme that does not map straightforwardly onto the standard Sanskrit astrological sequence; the rendered sequence follows the Tibetan text as literally as possible. "Protector of the World" at the western gate almost certainly refers to Virūpākṣa in some recensions, but as the Tibetan here uses a generic epithet rather than a proper name, it is translated accordingly. The four outer gate guardians in the Tibetan match the classical four Mahārājas (Lokapālas) by position; their names are supplied from that standard identification since the Tibetan gives only directional epithets for the last three. The term rendered "inauspicious body" for the northeastern direction reflects the Tibetan phrasiology for that direction in planetary-spirit liturgy; it is a standard directional designation, not a description of a being.
- The passage renders several Sanskrit dhāraṇī mantra syllables from Tibetan phonetic transcription. The transliteration follows standard reconstructions; some syllables admit minor variant readings but the overall sense of the mantra formula is clear. The mantra is presented here as a ritual text, not translated semantically, in accordance with standard practice for

dhāraṇī passages.

The phrase "Mother of the Planetary Spirits" renders the Tibetan gza' rnam kyī yum, literally "the Mother of the Planets," a standard dhāraṇī title in this genre.

The term rendered "poverty of demonic possession" follows the Tibetan dbul ba'i gdon, literally "the demon of poverty," a specific category of harmful spirit associated with material deprivation.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, indicating the text continues beyond the excerpt provided.

- The phrase rendered "month of Pisces" refers to the lunar month corresponding to the zodiacal sign of Pisces, continuing the astronomical context of the preceding passage. The colophon identifies the revisor as Drakpa Gyaltsen, a lay practitioner associated with Sakya, who compared the translation against a Chinese source text. The phrase "long version belonging to the royal ministers and bodhisattvas" is somewhat compressed in the original and likely refers to a recension attributed to or sponsored by that group; the exact provenance is unclear from this colophon alone.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.